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Ed Shaughnessy
Part II

Ed Shaughnessy may be the most recognized drummer in the country. His dynamic playing and vivacious personality have sparked the bands of Jack Teagarden, Benny Goodman, Duke Ellington and George Shearing. A native of Jersey City, Ed's first playing experience was in the clubs of the flourishing jazz scene on New York's 52nd Street. In the 50's he was kept busy in the studios and as a staff drummer with CBS television. As the Tonight Show drummer, Ed became a familiar face with nation-wide audiences and moved to Los Angeles with the show in 1972. When the Basie Band was in need of a drummer for recording, the Count would call on Ed and referred to him as his "Secret Weapon." He has recorded with jazz greats Oliver Nelson, Quincy Jones, Zoot Sims and Wes Montgomery. Ed is currently in demand at schools and colleges across the country and frequently appears at festivals and jazz parties throughout the world.

Ed was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 25, 1998 by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive on the Hamilton campus today. It's an extreme pleasure for me to welcome Ed Shaughnessy for actually Part Two of our interview series.

ES: Didn't get enough before, eh?

MR: No I just need another helping. It's been like two years, or three.

ES: I think it might be three. Yeah.

MR: And how many colleges have you visited since then?

ES: Oh I don't know. I'd hazard a quick guess and say twenty maybe, about.

MR: It seems to be a big part of your career to visit colleges.

ES: Yeah, it is a big part, and I'm very pleased with it because most of my stuff really comes in on recommendation. You know like one teacher will tell another teacher. I'm sure that's the way it happens because I don't have an agent out there hustling work for me. I really don't. So you really do it kind of by reputation. And as you know in that kind of work at colleges, and I do some high schools too, it's as much I think about your ease or ability at working with the kids as much as it is anything about your playing. I mean they assume you're going to play okay, but I really think getting along with the kids and trying to leave a good, inspirational and educational message, is an important part too.

MR: You had said something, I was re-reading our last conversation, that you enjoyed working with kids at this age because they haven't smelled the money yet.

ES: Yeah. I feel very strongly about that. I find that they represent what I was like at that age, in the sense of playing the music purely for the music and for the enjoyment and the pleasure and the thrill of it all. And you know I'll meet a high school guy, it's not uncommon for me to meet a high school guy ten years later, and sometimes he's the band director who hires me which is really cute. He played trumpet with me in the so-so high school band and now he's a band director at either a high school or a college. And that's really fun. And he'll say "you know we had the best time when you were at our high school." I say "did you really?" He says "man, you know I've remembered that night all through the years because the band was really up and we were swinging and—" well those are the kind of things, I mean it honestly gives me a chill to be able to tell you about it because that's so far away from commercialism and that whole area. It's what music is supposed to be about.

MR: Well I was observing in the hall last night, I should tell our viewers that we did a festival here and you played with Byron Stripling and so forth, and the kids were just going down the hall with their eyes wide open, like "oh, that was unbelievable." So those kids will have that same moment that you're describing.

ES: Sure. Yeah that stuff is really what I think bringing pros to campuses is about. I think that's what it's supposed to be about. It's supposed to be something deeper and more meaningful than "gee he played great." I mean that's fine and that's inspirational, it's always inspirational to hear someone that plays great. But I think if you've got some other stuff going where you're talking with kids and rapping with them a little bit and stuff like that, and trying the best you can to answer their questions, that means a lot to them, it really does. It's the whole package.

MR: You said as a kid you were a bit of a nut when it came to the drums.

ES: Yeah, I was a bit of a nut, but I find out, you know the longer I'm in the business and the more that I talk to other people, I find I was a rather common nut. I mean there's pretty much a thread that seems to run through. I'll give you an example. I knew Tony Williams quite well and I miss him very much with his very sad early demise. But Tony told me he himself has told me, although I've seen it in interviews too, it was nothing for him to practice six or eight hours a day on weekends when he was going to school. And it was nothing for him to practice three and four hours on school days. And Elvin Jones has said he used to practice eight hours a day any time that he could. So I don't think the fact that I tried to practice a great deal and play with guys in my neighborhood, I think it was pretty average for a guy who is really carried away with the music and his instrument. I found out I wasn't quite as much of a loner nut as I thought see.

MR: Well it's not a coincidence that those guys you named, including yourself, are the people at the top of their profession.

ES: Yeah. But sometimes you think, I think when I was young I thought that maybe — of course naturally I'm older than Tony Williams would be now, and Elvin's just a couple of years older than me. But I think sometimes when you're growing up you think that some of these great people, maybe they didn't work so hard at it practicing. They just rolled out of bed and it came about. But you find out later that with rare exception that's not true. They have worked a lot at it, really a whole lot at it. So yeah, I was kind of like that. But I was as much a fanatic to go to hear the music in New York. I've already told you before so I'm not going to recant that whole thing, recount that whole thing, but the fact that I could get from Jersey to New York on a ten cent subway token was very advantageous. If I lived out in the middle of Ohio or something, I couldn't have had that see. So I've always thought I was a lucky guy to have great jazz in proximity right up in all these little clubs in the famous 52nd Street that you know a lot about, and that a kid with very little money could sneak in those clubs and learn how to hide in a corner and that, and hear Charlie Parker and Art Blakey and Max Roach. Just think about that, I mean I'd say it's an unprecedented situation. And I don't know if it will ever exist again, mostly because if you go to the Blue Note today, a guy just told me, be prepared to put down twenty-five to thirty bucks to get in, and then you've got a couple of drink minimum. I haven't been to the Blue Note by the way, but it's like a lot of high priced clubs.

MR: I can attest to that.

ES: You can testify to that, right? I imagine you wouldn't want to go in there without eighty dollars in your pocket by the time you got out and with a tip and everything. See that's the difference.

MR: Do you think that jazz is doing itself a disservice with that kind of price thing? In fact I know that, I won't mention names, but a young, definitely in the category of young and up-coming artist I looked into getting here. And this particular person was charging more than people who'd been in the business for forty years. Just to come.

ES: You mean if you want to hire him.

MR: Yes. And I'm wondering well how did this happen? And are we pricing the music—

ES: Well baseball is all I can tell you. Maybe they're talking a leap from professional sports. I don't know. I'm not wise enough to know. I know that you can price yourself out of the business, that's been shown by a few people in the past, where they put such an astronomical price on their services that they start not to get called. But I'm really not that smart about the business end of it to tell you yes they are or nor they're not. I would say this, that I think in jazz, unless you're an unusual guy where the offers are just pouring in, and that doesn't seem to be most people, I think you'd be rather foolish not to play more for your own playing's sake than to hold out for that great big pie in the sky

money. I mean I admit freely, I've told you this before, if I'm getting a call from a high school with very limited funds, I do the best I can to get the Selmer folks to help out, they're very good, or the Sabian cymbal people help out, and I try to find a price that I think is fair for me but at the same time I'm adjusting it downward because they're not one of those high schools in an upper middle class area of the rich suburbs. I mean they're not. And it's sort of the same kind of a thing. And I'd rather go and play and I'd rather go there than not go there. You could sit at home and just say if I don't get X amount of dollars I'm not going. It's a free country.

MR: I keep coming across your name, the more I read about you, the things I didn't know you did, with Charlie Ventura?

ES: Yeah, that was my first national exposure.

MR: And Jackie and Roy were on the band?

ES: Oh yes. I would put his popularity at that time on a par with Chick Corea at his zenith, or any other group that you know had a zenith couple of years, you know what I mean by that? He was in a sense a very hot attraction. He was definitely a jazz band but he had that commercial tinge by the two kids singing the doodley, doodadly, beedeley vocals. And we would open like the Chicago State Theater, I mean we would be THE not opening act, we would be the closing act there, which was a very big theater, or any of the New York theaters that we played, we were the closing act. So for a period of about two to two and a half years, it wasn't very short-lived, it was very short-lived because Jackie and Roy went off by themselves, and he never quite regained the same height that he had with them. But to make a long story short, that was my first public exposure. I had been out with a couple of lesser big bands and toured around the country from the age of 17 for about two years, and then Charlie, I sat in and played with Charlie a couple of times on 52nd Street. And when he was forming this group he called me. So that was a really good job because he was a very nice man who encouraged you. Conte Candoli, we were the two babies in the band, the two young kids. Conte is about a year older than me so we like so say we've worked — now check it out — Conte and I are always telling people we've worked together for six decades right? 49 right? The fifties, sixties, seventies, eighties, and we're now in the nineties. And it's true, we've actually played together for six decades. We kind of think that's hip. See we caught the forties by one year. 49. Yeah one more year you'd say only five decades. And Conte and I are still playing together with Doc's band. I mean it's kind of fun, isn't it, to have a long association like that?

MR: Absolutely. And he still sounds good, too.

ES: Oh he sounds wonderful. He sounds just great. By the way, the Charlie Ventura stuff has been reissued on CD. It's never been on CD, you either had the big twelve inch LP's or

you didn't have it, and it just came out. And I talked to a guy, do you know who Gene Norman is?

MR: Yes.

ES: That's the producer of jazz concerts during the 50's and 60's. Well he put out the first half of a program, it was a live concert at Pasadena. It's the best thing we've ever recorded because it's really hot, imminent, you know you can hear the people and it swings real good. And I don't like everything that I've recorded, you know there's plenty of things I wouldn't even bother telling you about. But this I liked. It had a good, hot quality, and so I saw Gene Norman in a night club two years ago and I says "boy you're some guy." He said "what the matter with you?" I says "why don't you put the second half of our concert out?" He says "oh, that's right, I have a second half." I said "yeah, and people all over the country liked that, I'm signing the albums, why don't you put out the second half?" He says "boy you're really on your horse." I said "yeah, it was a good band, you've got to admit." "Oh" he said "it was a very good band, we sold a lot of records." So about a year ago, the guy says "hey the second half is out" Conte said the second half is out. So I hope I had a little result, yeah. I heckled him real good, like what a bad guy you are, you know, only putting out half a concert. That's a good record if you ever hear it. It's got a really good, hot quality. You know who Benny Green was? The fine black trombone player? He's passed now. He was a wonderful player, quite original, had all the Bebop stuff down but he kind of played it his way. He wasn't a J.J. clone, he wasn't a clone of anybody. He had a completely different style of playing.

MR: You've probably played on numerous albums over the years that your name wasn't printed on.

ES: Oh yeah.

MR: Or the names of the musicians weren't on.

ES: Oh yes. If I might interject it's annoyed me that the two best albums I made with Basie were called "Broadway Basie's Way," and "Hollywood Basie's Way," two separate albums on Command Records. Byron has them. He thinks they're great Basie records, 'cause Roy Eldridge was on one of them. And they have taken them both, and they've put them, I think Decca bought them up, and they've put them into a double album. I'm not talking CD now, I'm talking about LP. And a couple of years ago I spotted it in a store called Showtime instead of Broadway and — but there's not one person mentioned on the album. And I mean with due credit to all the fine soloists, not just myself. So somebody I know bought the album and said "oh did you record with Basie?" I said "yeah, I did five albums with Basie." He said "you know I just picked up a Basie album, 'Showtime.'" That meant nothing to me. He says "you know what I love about the drums on that album?" I said "what is it?" He said [sings] Strangers in the night [scats]. I said "that's

me playing." He said "I thought it was Sonny Payne." I says "that's a nice compliment, but no that's me, I made "'Strangers in the Night.'" So they have no idea whether it's me, and for people that don't know Lockjaw Davis, who was a great tenor player at the time with the band, they won't know it's Roy Eldridge unless they know their jazz history. So I'm giving a very long answer I hope you don't mind but you're absolutely right, when they don't list personnel, and they don't even list the period of time when it was made, this is important to a lot of people. The personnel particularly is important, and to you the sideman it's important. I'm proud of those albums. They are some of the best things I've ever made, really. Not just 'cause it's Count Basie, but because they came out very well and the feel was good, and Basie was happy.

MR: And the sound was great.

ES: Yeah the sound was good, and it's too bad when they do that, when one company buys them up like that that they decide we won't give any information, just a generic double Count Basie album. They took them and put them in one, two disks. So I hope sometime they'll correct that.

MR: Well I have it.

ES: You do have it.

MR: Chico O'Farrill arrangements.

ES: Yeah, Chico O'Farrill you have the original "Broadway" and "Hollywood."

MR: Yes I do.

ES: Okay. You and Byron [Stripling] are the only two people I know beside me. One thing I did, I was so knocked out with those, I enjoyed making them so much, it was a thrill of a lifetime. I don't mind telling you it was one of the great thrills of my life to record with Basie's band and have it go good, and he was happy, and the band was happy, and I was happy, that I did something I never did before, I ordered a dozen of each of those in a box, and I still have at least four of each after giving them to relatives and friends. And am I glad I did that you know.

MR: Yeah. Mint condition as they say in the record stores.

ES: Well in a way, yeah, the cellophane's still on them, sure. Because sometimes if they go out of print, you'll never get them again. Or if they go into that "Showtime" thing, well that's fine but there's no identification of you on the band or anything like that.

MR: That's right. They sometimes make odd decisions when they re-release things.

ES: Yeah, give me, that's my story, but give me from your point of view as an archivist. Do you have this problem sometimes when they'll repackage something?

MR: Yes. A lot of times they're just leaving out names and the dates. I mean in talking to other archivists and so forth — I don't even consider myself one yet —

ES: Well let's say you're working at it.

MR: That the dates may be messed up, and a lot of times when they do the CD things I have — one of my favorite albums was with Cannonball and Nancy Wilson.

ES: Oh that's a nice album.

MR: Capitol Records. And when the album came out they had vocal, instrumental, vocal instrumental, vocal, instrumental you know. When the CD came out, they put all the vocals in a row, and they put all the instrumentals at the end. And it really destroyed the continuity of the album. It was like you were at a club when you listen to it, and the singer would come up and do a tune, then the band would do a tune.

ES: Yeah, that sounds like nice pacing actually, the idea of instrumental, vocal.

MR: Right. So I don't know who's in charge here.

ES: Yeah there are some very funny things. And then you'll get the reverse, you'll get some of the companies that are very good and fastidious and they'll give you like the three outtakes on "How High the Moon" with the false starts and, I'll mean they'll really get down to it like that. But they'll do that. Like some of the new Miles Davis packages that are coming out. They'll give you four versions of a certain tune and things like that. I don't know if that's overkill. I guess to the student it's not, they might like to hear the variations you know. But I just don't think they should. I think jazz is such a personal music that I think it is unfair to not list the personnel, I really do. I mean I'm not just speaking for myself alone, but some kid listening to that record, and he hears this great trumpet solo and says "gee that's nice, I wonder who that is?" Well that trumpet solo, if it was on "Here's that Rainy Day" I think was Roy Eldridge. You know, the one and only time that Roy Eldridge ever recorded with the Basie band. That's what Byron said. "Hey man, that's history." That's what Byron likes about it. I said gee Little Jazz played so good, and it's unusual because he only was with the Basie band that short period of time. And they do a disservice I really do think. It's not such a big deal to just list the names. If you don't want to do all that annotation as they call it, about every tune, I wouldn't argue about that so much, you know. But I do think the personnel, with jazz stuff especially, it's a disservice to not list people.

MR: You know if your father hadn't brought home that drum set on the subway that day, do you think you would have continued with the piano? Because you said that you didn't love the piano.

ES: No I didn't love the piano. I didn't hate it but I didn't love it. Well I don't know because I had one other little connection to the drums. I was a Boy Scout and my scoutmaster, who I adored, I thought was a wonderful guy named Joe Rider. Joe taught drums, and he wasn't a sit down drum set player, he was a rudimental drummer. He had come out of drum corps and all of that. And I watched Joe once or twice when he was showing guys stuff on a drum pad before I played. And I was starting to get kind of curious about that.

So I'd like to think that if my dad hadn't brought home the drums I might have started in because Joe Rider the scoutmaster was teaching one or two guys in the troop. But I can't really tell you. If somebody said to me "if he had brought home a tuba do you think—" I said I don't know. It is funny. Somebody told me the same thing, who just told me was it one of our guys. Have you interviewed Houston [Person] yet? Did he tell you how he got the tenor?

MR: I don't think he did.

ES: Well it's worth repeating because it's like the Shaughnessy story of the drums, right? He said "we were all supposed to play piano in my family so I did a little piano. Then one day a Sears and Roebuck tenor saxophone showed up for me. I said "you mean they just got it?" He said "they just got it." And he started. Now he didn't ask for it. I said "you're like me and the drums." So I told him the drum story and he thought that was great. He said "man, it was given to us." He put a nice meaning on it. It was given. I said "that's right, Houston, it was given to us." But it was as abstract in a sense as my dad bringing a couple of old drums home in lieu of a debt. Because I said to Houston, I said "Houston, didn't you say to them 'buy me a Sears and Roebuck saxophone?'" He said "no I never did."

MR: So curious.

ES: It just showed up here.

MR: Here's a hard question for you. Sometimes music is hard to put into words.

ES: What's the secret of life?

MR: Well that's easy compared to this. I looked in the Webster dictionary this morning, under "Swing." It says "jazz music, especially from 1935 to 45, characterized by a strong driving rhythm and improvised counterpoint." Are you able, in talking to students or anybody in fact, to put what swing is into words?

ES: I finally think I can do it. I struggled with it for a long time. But I really think I can do it. The thing is before I do it I want to say to you how often swing is used as a noun representing the type of music. Right? They'll say the swing bands of the 30's and 40's, right? And they played swing. We're going to deal with it as — really how would you describe it if I'm going to go about swing as a feeling? Would we say it's still a noun but it's— I mean if I say "it swings" that's like an adjective, isn't it? Okay. Well I just want to make this clear to anybody who watches this tape. Because what I find the problem is sometimes is that youngsters, and even oldsters, they mix up the terms "to swing" and lock it in exclusively to jazz music. Now I think Bluegrass music swings like hell. It swings. Now what is that swinging I'm talking about? Without drums, right? It's infectious. The main thing I think that swing means, for me, is that it's an infectious beat that makes you want to move, whether it's to dance or to sit and tap your foot or to tap

your hands, but it makes you want to move in a sense, and in a response to it. It brings something out in you. It gets into you. Maybe it makes you happy. But mostly it makes you want to get with it. Infectious is the best word I can use. That's why I don't like the fact that someone, who is very hard-headed about anything other than jazz, like if I say to them sometimes, well you know some of James Brown's funk rhythms would swing you out into bad health. "Well I don't like Rock 'n Roll." I say look man [scats] — I say if you could hear that and you can't move yourself, you are dead, they should embalm you see? But that's a form of swing, do you know what I'm saying? If you hear a bunch of Africans playing [scats] and they're playing that twelve-eight stuff like the Watusi people do, and even if you don't see them dancing, if you hear that it's infectious. It gets you going too. So to me, any music, like Bluegrass, or Jazz, or Funk music or Watusi music, it's infectious and communicates to you rhythmically, and gets a visceral thing going. That's what I think swing is about. And I don't think it's an exclusive property of jazz. I really don't. However, some people will play jazz and it doesn't swing. That's the part that I think people should understand. To be swinging is a certain feeling. You can have jazz people playing but it ain't swinging too good see. So I think — I'm not going to say the mistake — but I think the error sometimes is to feel that if you're playing jazz it's necessarily swinging. No it's not necessarily swinging. You know? It might be a little cerebral, a little abstract, and you don't feel very much of that visceral communication. It might be very good, it might be very technical, but it isn't kind of getting to you. That's the absence of swing. That doesn't mean other things can't be there. Improvisation can be there. Imagination can be there. And feeling can be there. But I've heard for instance a bass and a drummer, both of whom were very good and well known, and they don't play good together. They are not compatible. It never settles into a good, unified pulse. So it isn't swinging too good. See?

MR: It's so curious the way—

ES: That's a good definition, don't you think?

MR: I like it, I love the word infectious.

ES: I'm not saying because it's mine, but I mean infectious is really what swing is about. Hey, yes. [snaps fingers] When I see audience, and I'm playing and I see some of that, it doesn't have to be everybody, if I see just a smattering of that, I think we're getting it across. And if I see nobody moving, I don't think we're getting it across.

MR: No, last night, a couple of times I'd look out and I could see some of this, and I'd say well, it's happening now.

ES: That's right.

MR: Is it harder these days, because we don't play for dances that much, for kids to learn swing, because the dancing seemed to be very much connected with swing music at that time.

ES: Well I don't know, that's a very good observation, I haven't really given it very much thought, but I think it's a good observation for the reason that you're mentioning, and that is the music of prior years that was still associated with dancing had to have a good feeling to make the dancers feel good. I'll give you a short story. I'm playing with Lucky Millinder at the Savoy Ballroom in the early 50's. And he says to me — I may have told you this story I don't know, I can't remember.

MR: It doesn't sound familiar.

ES: But I think it's a fun story, enough to repeat. And we're playing at the Savoy and it's my first week with the band and I followed Art Blakey, a hard chair to fill. And I'm like, what am I 22 years old? But they liked the way I played, blah-blah-blah. And I'm good enough that they didn't roast me. They let me learn. So we're up there the second or third night, and Lucky looks up at me, Lucky was an entirely self-taught musician, didn't read a note, and was one of the best band leaders in the business. He knew how to pace that band for that crowd. Keeping the Savoy crowd happy was a skill. If you didn't do it they would come toward the bandstand and grumble and talk to you. That's the way they were. Lucky knew how to do that stuff. He stood in front of the band with a little tambourine. Had time like a metronome, you know what I mean? He had that groove going with that tambourine and he just knew what to do. So he looks up and he says "boy" — which he loved to say to me, boy, kiddingly — "boy, you're going to play a whole chorus on the drums in the middle of this tune." The tune was "Idaho" [scats]. You may remember, it's a very old standard. I said uh huh. And he said "boy, if they stop dancing, you're dead." I said "yeah, okay, right Lucky." He says "don't forget, if they stop dancing, you're dead." So man I started out, and I went [scats] I didn't care what I played as long as it was swinging. And I probably played real simple, traditional [scats], man I wasn't going into no heavy Bebop or anything a little more technical or abstract, and nobody stopped dancing see? And afterwards he went [claps] okay. But that was a good lesson – "boy they'd better not stop dancing." See 'cause that was the big part of up there. By the way when we worked up there, there were two bandstands next to each other and the music would continually go. There wouldn't be a five minute break. We'd finish our last note, the echo, the next band starts up see. So that was good training ground up there, because Lucky had a heavy band. They played swing jazz, you know that type of stuff, like standards, but they played Rhythm & Blues too and that was a good training ground for me to get that kind of funky, shuffely — it's not Rock 'n Roll but I call it the father of Rock 'n Roll. 'Cause it had that backbeat built in and it had a

little heavier feel. You had to play more bass drum. You couldn't get away with just playing the lighter swing feeling. You had to dig into the drums more, which is why Blakey played it so good, because he had a really deep beat, you know a really deep sound. But that was a good experience. I worked with that band, I traveled down south with that band, and found out how they lived in houses instead of, they couldn't go into the hotels. Not in the 50's. They couldn't go into hotels. Did I tell you this whole thing about the houses?

MR: No.

ES: I don't think I did.

MR: Can we pause for one second? Is our microphone okay under his medallion there?

ES: Oh well I didn't notice that I'm sorry. How about if I do this, is that still okay? And I'll get it underneath the medallion. I didn't know that there. Is that all right?

MR: So in the 50's you traveled in the south with—

ES: Yeah I traveled in the south with Lucky's band. At that time I believe I was the only white guy in the band. At other times we had one or two other white guys in the band. But I think I'm actually — we did what's called the "chitlin' circuit" which was a group of theaters that they referred to as the "chitlin' circuit." You would do the Royal Theater in Washington — the Howard Theater in Washington, the Royal Theater in Baltimore, and I think there was one in Philly and I can't think of the name, and these of course were in predominantly black areas. And then you'd finish at the Apollo. So the "chitlin' circuit" was sort of a four theater circuit and you would do, generally I guess we did, I don't know if we did a week or maybe three or four days in each theater. But what I learned, that I thought was so interesting, and I think unless you travel with a black band you wouldn't really know this unless some black friends told you about it, but because they couldn't get into good hotels, they had a whole circuit set up throughout the country, I mean all bands, not just Lucky's, where you stayed in a private home with two or three other guys. You had a nice — these are the kind of women that kept meticulous houses, believe me. You had a lovely, clean room of your own. For a dollar at that time you could get an all-you-can-eat home cooked meal in the kitchen, you'd sit around a big table, and the lady would always say "hey honey if you come in late tonight there's a little cold chicken in the ice box," literally like be at home here. And even other amenities like if you needed a button sewed on the lady would do it, I mean never take money or nothing. And I thought to myself many times, out of adversity I lived better with Lucky's band than I had with Charlie's band. Because even though Charlie was very successful to a degree, we weren't making the huge money, the side men, that you could stay at the very best places you know. I won't say we stayed at bad places either, but in a way I liked the house thing better. It was more like a home environment you know. And they had a lot of

these strung out throughout the country that the black bands would stay at. And I thought it was a very enterprising thing that they did so that they didn't have to stay in really bad places.

MR: Did you ever get any grief, of being the only white fella.

ES: No. I never did.

MR: Never.

ES: I think that's why the polarization that has taken place to some degree in later years bothers me maybe a little bit more because I, luckily, worked in a period of time when if you played well, that was the badge of acceptance. And things started to change in the 60's, naturally with the social revolution that went on and this and that, and you know a white drummer in a black band wasn't popular at that time, it really wasn't, and I don't want to go into a great big diatribe about it, but it would be unfair to not say it's happened. It's even happening today to some degree. And I don't think I could have the same opportunity today that I had then. I honestly don't think so, and I'm sorry that it's that way because back then, even though we know there were many social ills and things that were very bad for black people, there was the advantage, for a white guy like me, to gain acceptance on the basis of playing only. It wasn't unhip for me to be in the band. But I know of — I'm not going into details — but I know of at least three or four situations where even the regular white drummer who had rehearsed with black groups has not been taken on tour, and he's been told quite frankly it wouldn't be considered too hip today for him to do that. Oh yeah. I mean these are situations that I've been told personally.

MR: Certainly a disservice to the music.

ES: Yeah, it's a disservice to the music, and you know, it's one of those things, I'm sure many black people if they look at this tape would say well we've certainly had enough problems in the past and this and that. But I love a thing that Abbey Lincoln said a couple of years ago. Somebody was talking about the predominance of black players in jazz. And I think anybody that knows jazz would say that's true. Fine. If you want to say 80%, I'm going to go real high, let's say we're going to make a general quote of maybe 80% of the most influential players have been black. I don't know if that's right. This is just an example. And Abbey said "yeah, I know, we may have had a lot to do with it but we don't own it." And I thought that was a very good statement. And Abbey was very politically active in the 60's. I know Abbey a bit. I knew Max when she was married, Max Roach when she was married to him, and she was quite active politically as was Max. And I've always admired them both for that because it wasn't easy on their careers to really stand up for what they thought was right you know, for black people's rights. But I liked what she said about we don't own it, meaning I can't sit here and say Kathleen Battle shouldn't be in the opera house, because she's not a middle-European

descendent. You know what I mean? Hey they own opera. Wouldn't that sound stupid? Or to say anything Leontyne Price has done. "Well it's negated by the fact that she's not a middle-European." And you're laughing because it's so silly.

MR: And like basketball was invented by a white man.

ES: Yeah right, that's right. You know it's kind of like that. It's kind of like that. And that's why it makes me a little bit sad to see some of the polarization that's going on. But don't forget, I'm sure you know, the polarization is beyond music right now, it's in a lot of areas of life. I'm sure you know that. You know on certain college campuses there's quite a polarization of people, the way they hang out, the way they— I mean I was in Oklahoma and in the cafeteria everybody was sitting mixed. There was black, white, green and yellow people all mixed up. And then I was in a more northern college, and I can't remember literally which it was and it doesn't matter anyway, and everybody was in clusters. There was a black table, there was an Asian table, and then there was a whatever table you know. And it was such a stark difference. Obviously there everything is group-wise. And in the Oklahoma college, which used to be called maybe more of a southern college, man it was a rainbow mixture. So that's just the times we live in. But I hope that we'll see a little more of the relaxed atmosphere. Our music, jazz music, was always sort of different in that respect. A lot of black and white guys got along like real brothers under the skin because of the music. And I always thought that was a great thing. I just, I did. I was lucky enough to live through that period of time when I even think a lot of the music was good with the inter-mixture of people. A lot of the groups that I belonged to that I thought were the best were the ones that were black and white. There was a great mixture of styles and things like that.

MR: Talking about mixtures of styles, could we talk just for a moment about when Rock 'n Roll came along? Were there particular drummers that seemed to catch on to the Rock 'n Roll thing? When I listen to some of the early Chuck Berry recordings it's really curious because Chuck is definitely into the Rock 'n Roll, but the rhythm section is trying to like feel out what's going on here. They're pretty much still playing swing.

ES: Well I wouldn't call myself at all a Rock 'n Roll historian, therefore I'll speak from the limited knowledge I have. I'm not a Rock 'n Roll historian, and I can only say what I've seen and witnessed and experienced. But what I saw happen was that a great many drummers and bass players couldn't cross over. What I mean by that is a lot of them who had a strictly jazz background couldn't get into the straight eighth and sixteenth feel. Some of them, many of them, didn't try hard enough. In my case, I came up strictly as a jazz drummer, right? And I wasn't thrilled by Bill Haley and the Comets at all. I mean to me it was real troglodyte rhythm, and you know so simplistic, I not only didn't pay attention to it, but I really didn't think it meant very much. No offense to Bill Haley, but

that's just coming as a jazz drummer, you know, that was way down the line to me. Then as the music got a little bit more sophisticated, especially with stuff like James Brown's rhythms and drummers, that really caught my ear because in a way it almost had sort of the improvisational stuff going on. The drummers were making up some really interesting beats, you know, sophisticated, based on the Rock 'n Roll straight feeling. And when that came along, as a defense, I'm not going to say I did it because I'm so altruistic, but I said I think I'd better get on the wagon, because the wagon is getting bigger. And I used to sit up in my little studio in New York where I taught on Saturdays and other days of the week, and I'd buy James Brown records, I'd buy Sly and the Family Stone, and I would sit and work with it. I'm not going to tell you, Monk, that I just said to myself hey I think I'll play some Rock 'n Roll. When you're used to going [scats] with the jazz twelve-eight feeling, to get into [scats], it's another thing, believe me. And I've got a pretty good ear and I catch on fairly fast, but I don't think anybody playing one style for let's say fifteen years, is all of a sudden just going to push a button and say hey, now I'll be a Rock 'n Roll drummer. So in my case, I liked the newer stuff so it wasn't as hard to practice it, and I put a lot of time in on it. Because it's funny but I'm glad I did because when I got on The Tonight Show, this was before The Tonight Show, in the 60's, when I got on The Tonight Show, in the very early 60's, and I got on Tonight Show I started in '63, I'd been doing this for a couple of years, on record dates and things. I was not a first call Rock 'n Roll drummer, there were plenty of other people like Bernard Purdie would have been a first call. That was his meat. He was the boss of that stuff. And very, very deservedly so, one of the great drummers. But I mean I had played a lot of gigs and worked where I had to play half rock half jazz. They called me for that. And then when I got on The Tonight Show, we definitely had a lot of Funk acts and a lot of Rock acts, so I'm kind of glad I broke the ice and did it for a couple of years. And quite frankly, that was a requisite on that show. If you were a drummer that only played very good jazz and you didn't play very good Rock, you couldn't have that job. I couldn't even call some subs that were wonderful jazz drummers but they didn't play Rock well, Doc [Severinsen] says don't call them. I had a complaint last night from an act because it's a Rock act and they don't play the style. So, seriously. I'm just saying that was a requisite of the job, because you had to play equally well. You didn't have to be a genius but you had to play professionally well. You had to understand it.

MR: Of course. Well if he had a jazz guest on the show and you had a person in the drum chair who could just do Rock stuff, they would say the same complaint.

ES: They would say the same thing. Yeah, that's a very good point. That's right. I couldn't call a guy who was a straight Rock player either, because his jazz stuff would be too weak. And big band jazz I think you really have to have a little more experience at than

small band jazz. What I mean is you have to have had also some big band jazz experience, not just combo experience. Because most combo drummers don't speak with a big enough sound for a big band. They don't know how to get a bigger sound. It's not a case of louder, it's a case of fuller. Like a good lead alto player, what does he need? A good, full sound, right? It's sort of like that. Or a good lead trumpet player. You have to know how to generate a fuller sound for that. So anyway, our original question, I hope we didn't wander off it, was that yes, some players adapted, and I'd say some players did not. And the players that did not soon found the work was really trickling away from them because there was such a little bit of jazz going on, even around New York. I mean the jazz clubs were all closing up, and it was a kind of a different scene that was going on.

MR: Was there a period of a number of years where, as you look back on your career, that were the toughest?

ES: The toughest?

MR: Oh let's say it was a struggle to find enough work.

ES: Well I'm a very lucky guy because the only time that I had that was in the beginning. I worked at the phone company, I'd had a couple of day jobs, and I only worked a few gigs at night, and I can honestly tell you that from the age of less than 18, about 17-1/2, I was earning a living at music. It was a small living, but I didn't have to work a day job anymore. See I graduated high school at 16, so I worked at the phone company from 16 'till about 17-1/2, and I put in my union card. You had to establish residence in New York. So I got a little one room, cold water flat, and I lived there and worked at the phone company and you had to put in residency for a year. You had to really live there. They'd come and check on you and all that. And I really feel very lucky. Once I started out with a couple of these traveling bands, like Randy Brooks and Bobby Byrne who were second or third layer bands, good bands by the way, quite good musical, played in tune, good bands and good leaders, they just weren't the Dorseys and the Goodmans you know. But from about 17-1/2 I really never had to take a day job, but I did have to collect unemployment a couple of times in between gigs. I'm not going to say I was on the gravy train, I wasn't. But I think once I got on Charlie's band and I got national attention, I don't think I had to collect unemployment. So I think after about 19 and 20, I was starting to earn my living pretty good after that.

MR: Do you think your father was pleased that that little drum set he brought home that day turned into a career for you?

ES: I'd love to give you a happy ending to that, but my dad left home, he and my mother broke up. It's not like he walked out, deserted, they decided to split about, I think when I

was 16 and I was just starting in really studying the drums. So he never really, I don't know what he knew later, I never saw him after that. Not once.

MR: No kidding.

ES: I tried to and, I don't know, I think my mom had told him it would be better to stay away and he and I always got along. He wasn't an abusive father, nothing like that. He was an alcoholic but not an abusive man. But I'm sorry to tell you I tried to look him up once or twice, he had moved and you know I'd like to think that maybe he knew that I was successful at drums because he brought the drums home, but I actually can't tell you. It's one of those things you know. Kind of lost in the past.

MR: You fellas on The Tonight Show must have been monstrous readers.

ES: Oh yeah, you had to be a cracker jack reader, yeah. Because the music came in at 3:15. You had a chance to play the tune once to make sure there was no wrong notes and kind of make sure there were no problems. Then the artist would go out at the mic as if it was the real show, without their costume on, and they'd put the lights on and everything looked like a show, and we'd play it a second time, and then the third time was during the show. So I'm not saying we couldn't play it another time, but on the average we played it twice before you heard it. That's the average. So everybody had to be a cracker jack sight reader, and again, good at shifting styles. Because one tune Tony Bennett would be on, boom you'd play a swing type tune. Maybe the next act would be Anita Baker [scats]. Did I tell you the story about Anita Baker? Do you remember a story about Anita Baker?

MR: No.

ES: Well I'll give you — this is what I call defensive listening, right? I'm not doing this to blow my horn but you had to do this. I used to do defensive listening in my car. Instead of putting in a jazz tape, I would turn on the radio and listen to the pop radio stations. Not my favorite music at all. But I'd listen a lot, get the feel, right? So Anita Baker comes up, and she's got this tune that's quite popular at the time, I can't remember the name. And I remember the way it goes, so I play the beat that's on the record, but it ain't on the music. The music is real simplistic, like one and two and you know. And I'm going [scats]. And she turns around. And after we get done she comes up to me and she says "you heard the record." I says "yeah." She says "thank you." She says "they still haven't changed that damn part and if there's anything I hate it's to hear [scats]. But I played the beat that I heard on the record. So that's how defensive listening sometimes would help you see? And I was pleased. Because you know your job, it's like Milt Hinton says, "when you're at gigs like that, you're performing a rhythmic service." That's what Milton calls it. And it's true. I mean you're there to help them to sound good. You're not there to blow your own horn see? So I always loved that. Because she came up to me as if she was going to scold me, and she says "ahhh, you heard the record." Like sneaky you know?

MR: Right. That's a good story.

ES: Yeah. But anyway, you're right about having to be, everybody in every chair had to be a very good reader. That's why kids that I see at clinics give me all this nonsense about, you know, why should I bother to read, and so-and-so doesn't read. I say that's fine and so-and-so isn't trying to go into a lot of areas of work that he can't do. He couldn't do The Tonight Show. That doesn't mean he's not a wonderful drummer. It doesn't matter who we're talking about, but there are a few guys that don't read out there. I say fine, but the point is you get more work if you can read. It's as simple as that. It's like let's say you can't read a book or you can't read an application, I mean yes there are some jobs, you could bag groceries the rest of your life or you might move up the ladder if you could read. It's the same thing. It's not that you can't get along, but why should you limit yourself?

MR: Yeah, that's a pretty old fashioned thing, like if I learn to read I'm going to lose my spontaneity.

ES: Yes or will it hurt my jazz is the old line. I don't want reading to hurt my jazz. Yeah. But you'd be surprised, some kids love to catch on to that because they don't want to have to want to bother. So you know what I say? 'Cause the example that was given for years was Buddy Rich see. So I would go at clinics "well Buddy Rich doesn't read, why should I read?" And my rejoinder is: "do you think you're as talented as Buddy Rich? If you are, you shouldn't be here you should be out earning like he did, at the age of four years of age." A thousand dollars a week in 1921. You think you're that talented? The highest paid, second highest paid child star in the world? Do you think that you're as talented as he was? That's when he was alive. And they say ohh. I say well see that's the difference. He could get by without reading because he had way more talent than most of us. And I of course say "most of us" because I mean it. Natural gift. He was the second highest paid child star to Shirley Temple I think.

MR: I didn't know that.

ES: Or Jackie Cooper. Yeah.

MR: As a dancer and—

ES: He was a dancer, he was a drummer, and he was Little Traps and he toured Australia and the world and he made a thousand dollars a week, which at that time I wouldn't even want to say how much money, and it was 1921, because he was born in 1917. And it was in like *The Guinness Book of Records* that he was the second highest child star in the world. Now that's a real, that's a Mozart prodigy. Doc [Severinsen] used to call him the Mozart of the drums. So that's what I try to use, you know, when they give me that thing. Today they might say it about another guy or two that I know who are very good drummers who don't read. But I keep saying to them, okay, I wonder if you're as good as

so-and-so? Now I'll use those names because Buddy's kind of gone you know, and I'll say "do you think you're as good" as so-and-so. "Well I don't know." I say "well if you're not well maybe you'd better read just in case you're not as good as him, see?

MR: Didn't they pull some stunts on him when he got on The Tonight Show a few times?

ES: Oh yeah, I had to make up a drum head on the big floor tom-tom that sits over here, you know the big tom? I had to make it up out of paper, and in between the rehearsal of course and the show. So he played on it, it was fine, and I had the guys make it days before, and we'd put this on, it looked just like a real nice drum head. And he never looks at anything. When he sat down, this is a rented set you know. And the first time he hits it he goes right through it and his whole arm went down and he turned around off mic and said "you son of a bitch Shaughnessy." He knew who did it, yeah. That's true. And another time I had them make up a cymbal, it looked just like a real cymbal, up on the left crash thing here? And they made it out of a plastic. They baked, they sort of baked a plastic thing. It looked just like a cymbal I swear. I don't know how they did it. I think they took the mold from the real cymbal. And the first time he hit it it exploded into a million things. We did both of those. Well he was a terrible prankster himself see? So you had to be able to take it, oh yeah.

MR: Did he ever get back to you?

ES: No, not really, I think he liked it, to be honest. It made so much laughs, so much fun you know.

MR: They had a classic Muppett episode he was one where he basically played the stage.

ES: Right. And in the middle he stops, he says "when I play a room, I play a room."

MR: That's right.

ES: I promised Bernard Purdie, Pretty Purdie, that I would give him a copy of that, he doesn't have it. And I saw him recently. I did a clinic with Louie Bellson, I arranged a couple of -- two drum deals you know, and we were up in Manchester, Connecticut about three weeks ago, and Bernard said "oh that sounds like such fun." So I said "I'll make you a dub and send it to you.

MR: What's in the near future for you? I know you're doing occasional tours with The Tonight Show Band.

ES: Yeah, we're doing either three or four tours a year with Doc Severinsen and The Tonight Show Band, and that's a lot of fun, because I have a lot of old friends in the band you know, and the band sounds great. And let me think, I've got, well I always do my two weeks of summer Teaching at Skidmore College up in Saratoga, New York. I look forward to that, that's a lot of fun. And generally I'll just keep doing what I'm doing, which is, I'm really back to doing what I did in the beginning, a freelance jazz drummer. I mean seriously. I'm kind of — the circles come around. The phone rings so you've got

an A&P Store opening, I come, they've got you booked at a Bar Mitzvah, I come, and I'm doing that, and I'm enjoying it. I like the variety of it, it's a lot of fun, and I have that mixture where I teach enough that I enjoy the teaching part of it. And it's about, I'd say 70% playing, 30% teaching. And I like that. And I'm happy with the mix. I don't really have any unrealized ambitions. I wish I'd get a little more work for my quintet that I have, but a lot of places that used to hire us like schools don't have quite enough money to bring five guys across the country, the air fares and everything are very prohibitive so we only do a couple of gigs a year. I wish we could do more because everybody likes the group and I have got guys that do good clinics, like on brass, reeds, piano, bass and drums. I like to do more with that group. But you just can do, even Phil Woods told me he's working more as a single now than he is with his group. As great as he is, and as wonderful a name as Phil has, but he told me lately he's been out more single. Same thing. Air expense. You deal with that all the time of course, trying to bring people in, don't you?

MR: Yeah. Well I want to compliment you on your professionalism too, as far as just dealing with business stuff. It made it much easier for me.

ES: Well thank you.

MR: I mean just little things like here's what I need to do, here's what it costs, and you can get your own plane ticket and that kind of stuff.

ES: Yeah, well I always think it's just as easy to do it because in a way it's good for me, I can leave a lot of time that's good for me, you know, I know when our traffic jams are for instance. Silly things like that but it's true. If you leave just a little bit earlier in L.A. you get ahead of all that madness, and I'd rather get up earlier and get ahead of the masses and stuff. But I'm glad, I hope it does help you. I'm pleased that you had us come out for this, this was really nice. And I know the kids enjoyed it a lot. I could tell by their reaction. In a way that's the most important part, right? They have a good time and they learn something. Now one drummer stopped me and he said "man" last night, after it was all over, he said "man, I'm going to go home and practice so hard, you've really inspired me." I said "that's the best thing you can say to me. I'd rather hear that then how did I play." He said "oh you played wonderful." I said "no, I didn't say that, I'm not fishing for you to tell me. I'm telling you that the best thing you could say is that I inspired you to go home and practice," because I said "that's what guys used to do for me." I'd hear some great drummer play and say "oh, I've got to go home and practice, I've got to get better." What a good example that was, of drumming. So that's the best compliment.

MR: Yeah. It's great that that circle is—

ES: Yeah that's what you hope to leave is a little inspiration, absolutely. How about you? I'm going to be devil's advocate and turn it around. Do you have any ambitions with your archives or anything like that that you hope to realize soon or in a while?

MR: Well first of all to get it open to the public, you know that's the first thing. It will be soon. We're figuring out how to disseminate the information in a way that honors the artist and so forth. There's just a lot of questions these days with the Internet and all that about putting all this stuff out there, keeping copyright issues in mind.

ES: Yes, it's a little touchy, isn't it.

MR: It gets more confusing as you go along. I have been very blessed with this project to associate with all my people that I listened to as I came up. Listening to these records and I'm always the type of person who loved to read the liner notes.

ES: I always did too.

MR: Who played on who?

ES: Oh I always like to read the liner notes.

MR: You know and now Snooky Young's with this band and—

ES: Oh yeah I always like to read the liner notes, in fact I was always disappointed they didn't have good liner notes or extensive liner notes.

MR: So now to get to talk to all these folks has just been a real treat and it's inspired me to write some new compositions that down the line maybe I'll record.

ES: So that's inspired you a little bit?

MR: Yeah.

ES: That's terrific. Just let's say generally speaking, have you hoped to possibly make your archive stuff accessible on the Internet possibly? I'm just saying possibly.

MR: I think the plan is right now to put samplings out with some visuals perhaps, you know, have to get a web site up and put samples of things and of course list the people we have.

ES: Yeah it seems to me that that would be the right step. I mean the idea of having everything available on the web, I mean first of all it's such a huge undertaking that I couldn't conceive how long it would take. But putting samplings to show people who might be interested, who might like to come, that would be what it's aimed at, isn't it? To show what we have, the kind of stuff that we have?

MR: Absolutely.

ES: Yeah. That would really give you exposure as they say.

MR: Yeah. We've been contacted from *Down Beat* magazine about perhaps using, they have a satellite thing set up where the might beam stuff down to some schools that don't have music programs.

ES: Oh yeah.

MR: So that' sounds like something for us.

ES: Now that's kind of good, yeah, isn't that wonderful, to places that don't have anything much in the way of good library books on jazz or any source of history, huh?

MR: Yeah.

ES: Oh yeah. I'll tell you, as we all know, there's no limit to the good stuff that the Internet can do. It's even done a few good things for me. I've told you I've found guys that have tapes of albums that I've lost or given away or something, and they're nice enough to send them to you. Gee it's terrific. I had a guy from Scotland send me an e-mail and he says "we're the Jimi Press" J-I-M-I, they're the biggest Jimi Hendrix fan club in the world. We know, now check this out, we know that April 19, 1969, you played with Jimi Hendrix when his drummer got sick. Now I know I played with Jimi Hendrix, do you think I could have told you what year it was? Much less what day it was? "And we wonder if you would be kind enough to write a few paragraphs, and either e-mail or mail us for our Jimi Press, a monthly publication see? So I get back to them by e-mail and I said "sure I'd be glad to do that for you guys," I said Jimi was a very colorful character and I can give you a couple of cute anecdotes, you know, leopard-skinned pants and me saying to Doc Severinsen, "I ain't playing with no Jimi Hendrix and a suit and a tie." And he said "no, you don't want to do that," so I took off my tie, took off my jacket, rolled up my sleeves, and you know at least I fit a little better, with Jimi Hendrix's snake-skinned pants and rainbow shirt and all of that. And anyway, the story is that I did do this for them, I wrote a couple of paragraphs out about what transpired that day and what tunes I thought we had rehearsed, and they corrected me on one of the tunes. I mean they've got some stuff. And then do you know what they did? They said "you've been so nice," and they published it and they sent me a copy, and they sent a note with the magazine and they said "you've been so nice about helping us out with this, that we're going to trace down the bootleg copy of you playing with Jimi Hendrix that is around Europe in a few places, not video, because they didn't have video cameras. And last week, the tape arrived from London. They found a guy in Germany and he ran a copy, he's a Jimi Press fan, sent it to them and they sent it to me. Now that's what I mean. The web has got such good positive stuff like that you know. Now I haven't listened to it, you know I was busy and I've been traveling, but it's fun to have it. I mean where else would I have found a tape of playing with Jimi Hendrix? Just through these guys, right? They know everything. I mean Jesus. They knew Johnny Carson was off that night and Flip Wilson was the sub host. I don't remember that. You know, I did over five thousand shows, am I supposed to remember who was hosting April 19, 1969? These dudes know, don't ask me how they know. And everything they say is right. Oh by the way, you played "Lover Man" too. I had said we played something with fire in the title, a famous Jimi Hendrix tune, Fire

something. And they said "that's right and you also played 'Lover Man,'" which I had forgotten.

MR: Did it swing?

ES: I don't know. I'll tell you, they say it sounds real good.

MR: Wow, fascinating.

ES: Oh yeah, and Jimi blew out all the wires in the NBC main cable by stepping on an effects pedal that they told him not to hit. In rehearsal he touched it and everything went cheeew. And they said "Jimi, don't use that pedal, because it's an overload on the main cable." And during the show he got hot and I thought to myself I'll bet he's going to hit it. And he went yahhhhh, and he blew out that line, and we stopped and they had to put in a new line, and then we went on again.

MR: No kidding.

ES: Yeah. That was a funny incident, it really was. He was a lot like Charlie Mingus, I think that's why I got along with him. He was kind of a real independent, I don't know, it's hard to describe, but if you knew Charlie Mingus, that was, Jimi was like that. You just deal real direct with him, real straight, this, that, "play loud as hell and give me a lot of cymbals, Ed." I said "okay, Jimi, I'm going to do the best I can." He said "I heard you play with Charlie Mingus, it's going to go fine." Yeah. That's the way it was, it made you feel good, relaxed.

MR: Cool. Well listen, thanks for your time today.

ES: My pleasure. Thanks for having me. It's great to be up here with you and see where you keep all your records man, with the spider's webs on it all.

MR: Guess what we got in here. All right. We'll see you again I'm sure.

ES: I hope so, Monk, thank you.